

5.4 Your Personal Mailman: Organising Your E-mails

5.4.1 Creating And Maintaining Folders

As we mentioned earlier, you can create your own mail folders in Outlook. To do so, go to **File > New Folder**, and specify the name of the folder, what it will contain, and which folder you want to make it a subfolder of. You can thus create several folders—say one for personal mails and one for office mails; then, within the ‘office’ folder, one for co-workers and one for senior colleagues, and so on. This is useful as your Inbox isn’t cluttered with mails all the time, and you can easily find a message when you need it. Of course, you can always search for mails based on certain criteria, but what if you don’t remember enough about a mail to be able to search for it? If you organise your folders effectively, you won’t need to search nearly as often.

5.4.2 Auto-directing Your Mail To Specific Folders

Once you’ve set up your personal mail folder hierarchy, you can make Outlook automatically direct mails to these folders, instead of dumping everything in your Inbox. Here’s how.

Go to **Tools > Rules and Alerts**. The ‘Rules and Alerts’ dialog box opens up. To start creating a new rule, click ‘New Rule’. This opens up a wizard. You can choose to create a rule from scratch, or use a template. Templates exist because many rules are used very often, for example, to move messages from a specific person to a specific folder. Of course, if you choose to create a new rule based on a template, you’ll need to edit it to suit your requirements. It’s easy to use a template—simply click ‘Start creating a rule from a template’, and it’s intuitive. Let’s do it the slightly harder way—creating a rule from scratch. Click ‘Start from a blank rule’.

In the Rules wizard, you’ll see ‘Step 1: Select conditions’, and ‘Step 2: Edit the rule description’. Depending on what you choose in the top box (see figure below), the description changes in the box below. Let’s take the example at the top of the first box: ‘from